LoTM Pathway Creation Guide

A design manual for building pathways and sequence abilities with a consistent power budget for both human authors and AI-assisted drafting

Built for a dnd5e-derived Foundry implementation adapted to Lord of the Mysteries-style progression

How to use this guide

Use it as your private framework when writing pathways by hand, and as a standing rules document when asking AI to draft sequence packages.

Purpose

This guide gives you a repeatable way to build LoTM pathways without forcing every pathway to play the same way. The core principle is simple: each sequence has a power budget, but different pathways spend that budget differently. A Seer can be balanced against a Warrior without having the same damage profile, because the Seer may spend more of its budget on information, setup, subtle control, and narrative leverage.

Use the budget as design currency, not as raw damage. A sequence is balanced when its total influence on the campaign matches its tier.

Core principles

- Do not equate power with damage alone.
- Price abilities by practical impact in play.
- Every sequence should add a clear fantasy and a clear upgrade delta.
- Upper sequences should unlock new kinds of influence, not only larger numbers.
- Abstract pathways are valid as long as their leverage is bounded and priced.

Glossary

Term	Meaning
Total budget	The full power allowance for a character at that sequence.
Gain budget	The increase in budget when advancing from the previous sequence. Use this when designing the new sequence package.
Power vector	How a pathway spends its budget across offense, control, utility, survivability, information, ritual leverage, and narrative authority.
Narrative authority	An ability that changes what facts, access, information, or causal leverage a character can obtain.
Limitation discount	A cost reduction because the effect is risky, costly, preparation-heavy, or unreliable.

Power model by sequence

Treat Sequence 9 through Sequence 0 as a cumulative progression. The total budget reflects full expected capability at that sequence. The gain budget reflects how much additional power a promotion should add.

Sequence	Tier index	Total budget	Gain budget
9	0	2	-
8	1	5	+3
7	2	18	+13

6	3	27	+9
5	4	40	+13
4	5	73	+33
3	6	93	+20
2	7	143	+50
1	8	217	+74
0	9	331	+114

Design note

These numbers are tunable. What matters is the shape: modest early growth, stronger mid-tier jumps, and steep late-game increases so Sequence 2, Sequence 1, and Sequence 0 feel qualitatively larger.

Recommended role of each tier band

Band	Sequences	Expected feel
Low Beyonder	9-7	A few supernatural edges, narrow advantages, limited reliable impact.
Developed Beyonder	6-5	Reliable tools, stable encounter influence, signature identity online.
Saint transition	4-3	Regional threat or specialist dominance; larger rituals and stronger leverage.
Angel tiers	2-1	Mythic influence, conceptual edges, campaign-warping impact when prepared.
God tier	0	Qualitative change in authority and scale.

Pathway construction framework

Build each sequence with the same seven-step workflow.

1. Write a one-sentence sequence fantasy. What does this sequence let the character do that the previous one could not?
2. Set the target budget. Use the total budget for a full package and the gain budget for a promotion package.
3. Choose a power vector. Decide how much of the budget goes into conflict, information, movement, ritual leverage, survivability, control, and narrative authority.
4. Draft 3-6 features: usually one signature feature, one support feature, one passive trait, and optionally one ritual or prep-based feature.

5. Score every feature with the rubric. Record base cost, modifiers, discounts, and final cost.
6. Check domain coverage so the sequence is strong where it should be strong without solving every problem at once.
7. Run the balance checklist. If it overruns the game, reduce reliability, frequency, scope, or setup ease before cutting the fantasy.

Suggested feature mix by sequence

Sequence band	Typical package	Active features	Common shape
9-7	Small toolkit	2-4	One signature trick, one passive, one minor utility or control effect
6-5	Established kit	3-5	Signature feature plus one reliable encounter tool and support effects
4-3	Expanded authority	4-6	Stronger rituals, stronger control, or broader battlefield or social presence
2-1	Mythic toolkit	4-7	Very strong signature effects plus costly or preparation-heavy authority
0	Tier-defining package	3-6	Few but defining abilities with clear campaign-level consequences

How to quantify subjective abilities

Utility, control, and narrative authority only feel unmanageable when they are judged as vibes. To make them tractable, score each feature on measurable axes and then adjust for limitations.

Step 1: assign a base function score

Function	Minor	Moderate	Major	Extreme
Damage / direct offense	3	6	10	15
Control / denial	4	8	13	19
Utility / mobility / perception	2	5	9	14
Survivability / defense	3	6	10	15
Information / divination	3	6	11	17

Narrative authority / causal leverage	5	9	15	22

Step 2: apply impact modifiers

Modifier	Adjustment	Guideline
Scope	+0 / +2 / +5 / +8	Single target, few targets, scene-wide, or broad area
Reliability	-2 / +0 / +3	Hard to set up, normal reliability, or near-certain effect
Duration	+0 / +2 / +4 / +7	Instant, rounds, scene, or persistent
Frequency	-3 / +0 / +2 / +5	Rare or ritual-only, encounter-limited, reusable, or near at-will
Stacking potential	+0 / +2 / +5	Low synergy, noticeable synergy, or abusable layering
Counterplay reduction	+0 / +2 / +4	Can be interrupted, limited counterplay, or very hard to stop

Step 3: subtract limitation discounts

Limitation	Typical discount	When to use
Preparation time	-1 to -5	Meaningful ritual time, setup turns, or advance planning
Material or sacrificial cost	-1 to -4	Consumes money, rare resources, or painful tradeoffs
Madness / corruption risk	-2 to -6	Using the feature meaningfully endangers the character
Restricted trigger	-1 to -4	Works only in narrow conditions or against narrow targets
Backlash on failure	-1 to -5	Failure causes serious harm, exposure, or lost control
Shared resource pressure	-1 to -4	Competes with a very scarce pathway resource

Rubric formula

Final feature cost = base function score + impact modifiers - limitation discounts. Use a believable range instead of false precision if needed.

Step 4: test domain impact

After scoring the feature, tag which play domains it affects. A pathway can be weak in direct combat but strong in investigation or ritual leverage and still be balanced.

Domain	Questions to ask	Typical pathways	Risk if overbuilt
Combat	Can it win or swing a fight directly?	Warrior or Hunter-like	Damage inflation, hard control loops
Investigation	Can it reveal hidden information or truths?	Seer or Sleepless-like	Plot bypass, spoiler play
Infiltration / mobility	Can it reach, escape, hide, or reposition unusually well?	Apprentice or traveler-like	Encounter invalidation
Social / influence	Can it compel, deceive, or shape behavior?	Manipulator or audience-control kits	Conversation auto-win
Ritual / occult prep	Can it reshape outcomes with time and resources?	Mystic and scholar kits	Off-screen omnipotence
Survival / corruption	Can it absorb danger or endure backlash?	Resilient and fate-buffer kits	No meaningful cost for using power

AI operating specification

Use this section as a standing instruction block whenever you ask AI to help build pathway content. The AI should not simply brainstorm cool ideas. It should produce a structured draft that obeys the budget and explains its scoring.

Required AI rules

- Treat the sequence budget as a cap, not a suggestion.
- Preserve pathway identity rather than distributing budget evenly across all domains.
- Price features by actual impact in play, not by flavor text.
- Bound narrative authority by scope, frequency, preparation, and reliability.
- If a package exceeds budget, reduce reliability, frequency, scope, or ease of use before cutting the core fantasy.
- Output both the total cost and the reasoning used to arrive at it.

AI input template

Field	What to provide
Pathway	Name and one-sentence fantasy
Sequence	Target sequence and whether the AI is building the total package or only the gain package
Budget	Target total budget or gain budget from this guide
Priority domains	Which domains should be strongest, secondary, and intentionally weak
Tone	Combat-heavy, intrigue-heavy, investigation-heavy, occult-heavy, or mixed

Hard constraints	Anything the pathway must include or must avoid

AI output template

Section	Required content
Sequence summary	A short statement of what this sequence changes in play
Budget overview	Target budget, projected spend, and any intentionally reserved budget
Feature list	Each feature with name, description, domain tags, and cost breakdown
Power vector	How the sequence spends its budget across offense, control, utility, survivability, information, ritual leverage, and narrative authority
Balance notes	Why the sequence is fair relative to its tier and what keeps it from overrunning the game
GM flags	Adjudication notes, edge cases, or abuse risks

Reusable AI prompt

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Create a pathway sequence package for a Lord of the Mysteries-inspired TTRPG.

Use the attached pathway creation guide as the authority for budgeting and balancing.
Pathway: [NAME]
Sequence: [NUMBER]
Package type: [TOTAL PACKAGE or GAIN PACKAGE]
Target budget: [NUMBER]
Priority domains: [LIST]
Tone: [LIST]
Hard constraints: [LIST]

Requirements:
1. Produce a sequence summary.
2. Draft 3-6 features appropriate for the sequence.
3. For each feature, provide a cost breakdown using base function score, modifiers, and
limitation discounts.
4. Tag each feature by play domain.
5. Keep the total at or below budget.
6. Explain how the package stays faithful to pathway identity while remaining balanced.
7. Flag any feature that may need GM adjudication.
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Worked micro-example

Two Sequence 7 gain packages can spend the same budget very differently and still be balanced.

Warrior-like package

- Enhanced melee pressure and a brief burst of physical dominance.
- Danger-sense passive that raises survivability but does not reveal broad hidden truths.

- Most of the spend goes into direct offense and survivability.
- Approximate spend: 18.

Seer-like package

- Spirit vision, omen reading, subtle misdirection, and danger intuition.
- Much lower direct damage but stronger investigation, setup, and prep value.
- Most of the spend goes into information, utility, and light control.
- Approximate spend: 18.

Validation checklist

- Does the sequence have a sharp identity rather than a pile of unrelated tricks?
- Does the total or gain package stay within budget?
- If the pathway is abstract, are its high-impact features bounded by frequency, scope, setup, or risk?
- Would this sequence still matter if the campaign de-emphasized its best domain?
- Does the package create interesting decisions rather than automatic wins?
- Could another pathway of the same sequence oppose it meaningfully in at least some situations?
- Does the sequence add something qualitatively new instead of only inflating previous numbers?
- At high tiers, does the package change scale without erasing all need for preparation, cost, or counterplay?

Pathway worksheet

Use this as your manual drafting sheet or ask AI to fill it out.

Field	Notes
Pathway name and fantasy	
Sequence target	
Total or gain budget	
Primary domain	
Secondary domain	
Intentional weaknesses	
Signature feature	
Support features	
Passive traits	
Ritual / prep features	
Risk and corruption hooks	
GM adjudication notes	